



BEFORE

Large-scale architecture was one of the earliest features of civilization.



STONE BUILDINGS,
GOBEKLI TEPE, TURKEY

NEOLITHIC BUILDING

Early Neolithic-period **◀36** stone structures include walls in Jericho, now in Palestine (c. 8500 BCE), and a possible stone temple at Gobekli Tepe in Anatolia, now Turkey (c. 9000 BCE).

TEMPLES IN MESOPOTAMIA

The oldest known structures in Mesopotamia are temples dating from the Ubaid Period (5900–4300 BCE). On sites long held **sacred**, the temples were rebuilt many times.

PITS AND MOUNDS IN EGYPT

Tombs in **predynastic Egypt** (before 3100 BCE) were simple, sand-covered pits. Early royal tombs were elaborations of this model, covering a rock-cut chamber with a **mound of sand**.

FIRST MONUMENTS IN THE AMERICAS

Mud-brick platforms called **huacas** appear along the coast of Peru **◀74** from 4000 BCE. Used as **ritual sites**, they were often built in pairs.

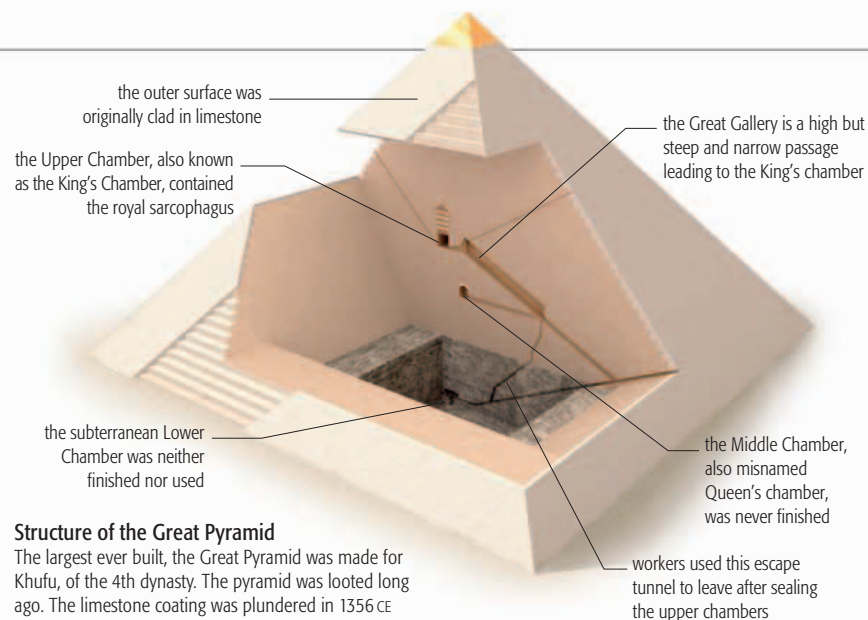
Mortuary temple of Queen Hatshepsut

After the Old Kingdom came to an end, fewer pyramids were built and attention shifted to the mortuary temples. These were often built at the foot of cliffs, which were possibly viewed as natural pyramids.

A Almost every form of ancient Egyptian monumental architecture can be interpreted as part of a temple. The pyramids were not isolated structures, but parts of mortuary (memorial) temple complexes. Egyptians believed that their kings became gods when they died, so the tombs were dedicated to their worship.

The first pyramid, the Step Pyramid, was built c. 2667–2648 BCE (see Imhotep, p.56) for pharaoh Djoser of the 3rd dynasty. The design probably evolved from the earlier sand mounds that covered tombs (see BEFORE). True pyramids appeared in the 4th dynasty, the first being built for pharaoh Snefru in c. 2580 BCE. It reveals a move toward the use of solar imagery in its imitation of the rays of the sun. The “Pyramid Texts,” which were religious inscriptions on the walls of later pyramids, refer to the pharaoh ascending to join the god Ra (see p.68) on a solar barque—a mythical boat in which the sun rides.

Egyptian temples were carefully constructed models of the universe. The inner sanctum represented the ordered heart of creation, and the temple’s



Structure of the Great Pyramid

The largest ever built, the Great Pyramid was made for Khufu, of the 4th dynasty. The pyramid was looted long ago. The limestone coating was plundered in 1356 CE to rebuild Cairo after an earthquake.

outer walls, the cliffs at the edge of the Nile Valley, held back the chaos that lay beyond. Colonnades (rows of columns) and hypostyle halls (halls with pillars holding up the roof) represented the riverbanks, with the columns denoting reeds, while the ceilings symbolized the sky, and were decorated with images of stars and the sun. Palaces too were built along the same lines. Pharaohs

gained such prestige from their building programs that some even appropriated the projects of their predecessors, erasing their names and claiming them as their own.

The step towers of Mesopotamia

In Mesopotamia (a region made up of what is now Iraq and parts of Syria, Turkey, and Iran, see pp.54–55), the

Building for Eternity

The construction of monuments, such as temples, palaces, and tombs, was one of the key features of developing civilizations. Most monuments had religious functions and were intended to legitimize the position of the rulers who built them by connecting them with the gods.

